

THE MUNNABHAI MYTH

A Bandra bad boy's excesses were airbrushed in the afterglow of an iconic hero

Like everything else in his life, good and bad, Sanjay Dutt's perfect virtual alter ego, the goofy, good-hearted goon Munnabhai, happened by accident. Dutt was all set to play a minor character, when Shah Rukh Khan turned *Munnabhai MBBS* down because of his bad back. Having stepped in, Dutt, never the thinking actor, had no clue about its history-making potential, but went through the motions of filmmaking, trusting producer Vidhu Vinod Chopra.

Yet nothing has done more to erase Dutt's image of a Bandra bad boy with a penchant for chasing chicks and downing drinks. The Munnabhai persona, playing on Dutt's innate doltishness, freed him, he thought forever, from the stigma of being the *Khalnayak*. "*Munnabhai MBBS* was not just another Friday hit," points out co-star Boman Irani, "It became a lifetime of success. Nobody could ever take it away from him." It was a cult that acquired even more mythical proportions when Munnabhai channeled Mahatma Gandhi in *Lage Raho Munnabhai* in 2006.

In Bollywood's pretend world, Dutt, even at 48, will remain a Sanawar school baba, the hell-raising son who never overcame his mother's death from cancer in 1981, the *bhai* who loves to see happy faces around him, and the whipped little boy who was always afraid of his fiercely correct father, but had to nonetheless turn to him repeatedly. After Munnabhai, Dutt was not just a boy behaving badly, dumping women, doing drugs and flaunting guns, but a naïve savant, a *Forrest Gump* trapped

in a Marlboro Man's body. Dutt became more than just another star. He became an institution, the dispenser of homemade homilies and the illusionist of redemption, a cinematic version of his father Sunil Dutt's social work, without the sweat. By the second film, Dutt was a firm believer in the magic of the Munnabhai idea. At pack-up, he would ask, so what's happening tomorrow? He wanted to discuss scenes. It was unheard of.

Munnabhai was not just a lifeline for Dutt—saving him from playing a series of moronic villains after

him, for audiences to believe he was, after all those conversations with headline-making dons and 16 months spent in the company of hardened criminals, just a nice, misunderstood guy.

It wasn't as if Dutt had not played a hero before *Munnabhai*. *Mission Kashmir*'s Inayat Khan was a hero who gave a stirring patriotic speech, while *Parineeta*'s Girish was the unselfish gentlemanly lover. It's just that no one else had the tapori touch, acquired no doubt through years of **MAGICAL MAKEOVER: In *Khalnayak* (right); as Munnabhai**



Despite his gangster movies, audiences loved Dutt's sad-eyed honesty.

Vaastav—but also perhaps an escape. One which allowed him to retain his on-off flirting-with-danger lifestyle, with its often hedonistic excesses. But unlike smarter stars who strategise about image, there was no hyper-kinetic marketing to build on the persona. That sad-eyed honesty is what audiences loved. Sure, he would do his guns-girls-gadgets movies with buddies like Sanjay Gupta and Bunty Walia, but all he had to do was smile shyly as Vidya Balan's Jahnvi kissed

dealing with drug pushers and gun smugglers, but passed off as a man-of-the-people manner. If there is sympathy for Dutt, it stems from that. How can a man who doesn't understand the consequences of his actions be punished for them? "You could call it innocence or ignorance," says Subhash Ghai, but what made him distinct from other Bollywood brats was this: if he was lethal, it was usually to himself.

If this were a movie, the nation could give Munnabhai a collective *jadoo ki khushi*. But it is not. And the best-known inhabitant of Arthur Road Jail is not Munnabhai a.k.a. Murli Prasad Sharma. He is just the son of Mother India who never grew up.

by Kaveree Bamzai